COMPLIANCE

ELEVATED

DATA SUBJECT ACCESS REQUEST

A customer has invoked their GDPR right to erasure. They want all data deleted across every system, with written confirmation, within 72 hours. You have never done this before. It involves six different data stores across three teams.

GDPR Article 17 (right to erasure) and Article 15 (right of access) impose strict timelines — 30 days for access requests, with fines up to 4% of global annual revenue for non-compliance. The engineering challenge is that personal data is rarely in one place: it exists in primary databases, analytics pipelines, event logs, backups, third-party integrations, and caches. A data map — documenting every system that stores personal data and how it is tagged — is the prerequisite for scalable DSR handling. Automation tools (OneTrust, Transcend, or custom pipelines) can execute deletion workflows across systems in response to a request, generating an audit trail automatically. This is fundamentally a data architecture and observability problem, not just a legal one.

GDPR is not an edge case. Every user you have is a potential DSR. Manual processes do not scale past a handful of requests.

TEAM DISCUSSION

Is data erasure automated across all systems, or does it require manual coordination you hope someone remembers how to do?